development aid, military assistance), (3) whether engagement could work or whether containment was necessary, and (4) whether one should go it alone or turn to collective security or a diversified set of partnerships.

Between 1949 and 1956, India believed that whatever short-term symbolic and long-term geopolitical threat China posed could best be dealt with by integrating it into the international community, and engaging China, with an emphasis on the use of diplomacy rather than force. Years later, the US government would come to that conclusion between 1969 and 1972. During both those periods, the US and India took opposite approaches with China to the detriment of their bilateral relationship.

In the second half of the 1950s and the early 1960s, China brought the US and India together on both the defense and the development fronts. At this time, their perceptions of China as a geopolitical and ideological threat were similar. They also agreed on what to do about China. Finally, each saw the other as playing a key role in its China strategy.

This agreement unraveled between 1963 and 1968. Even as the two countries agreed that China was a threat, they differed on the extent and urgency of the threat and what needed to be done to deal with the challenge. These disagreements led to doubts about the other country's utility and thus the partnership—and led to its eventual unraveling.

Between 1969 and 1972, differences on perception of and policy toward China would lead the US and India to the nadir of their relationship, just about a decade after China had taken them to its zenith.

Finally, between 1973 and 1979 China disappeared as a key raison d'être of the relationship. India's decision to engage with China, as the US was already doing, alleviated a source of strain; so did the fact that the US no longer saw India as a major spoiler in its engagement with China. Simultaneously, however, the two countries slipped down each other's priority list as they struggled to find major shared interests.

The Tangled Triangle

Even at a time when the three countries were not as entangled as they are today, the US and India could not stovepipe their relations with each other from their relations with China. How Beijing and Washington perceived each other—as strategic partners or strategic competitors—affected Delhi's